

tant, but it remains a big problem. Now, with the electronic system, if you violate the law, the camera captures it. We need a fully intelligent traffic system everywhere to create awareness in people's minds. Public education is also crucial, especially in schools. It's time for the country to ensure that state governments teach students the importance of road safety and the rules of the road.

Q. The other issue is in terms of ambulances and their capacity to reach on the spot, what they call the golden hour—what has been done to improve that?
We have improved the ambulance situation and are working with state governments. We introduced the 110 number and also ensured that if dialled, the ambulance reaches the spot in 15–20 minutes. But the problem is that if there's an accident involving a car or bus, and the vehicle is in such a position that we need to cut it open, there is no equipment available for that. We have made two things mandatory for toll plazas—a crane, and an ambulance. The new code will ensure that ambulances are equipped with ventilators, other essential medical equipment, and a trained compounder who can administer saline and other necessary treatments. Additionally, they will have engineering tools to cut through a vehicle.

Q. Is there a shortage of trauma care hospitals to treat road accident victims?
We tried to plan some trauma centres, but since the subject falls under the health ministry, the initiative was stopped at that time. Even now, we are saying we will give the land free on highways for such trauma care centres.

Q. Why can't these trauma facilities be included in the toll plaza concessionaire's site?
It's a totally different subject because we need specific infrastructure, manpower, doctors and other resources, which fall under medical science. For that reason, we need to approve hospitals, and this is very important. The best approach we're considering is to ensure that everyone knows the nearest trauma centre from any given point. The distance will be specified, and an ambulance will take the patient to the hospital within 15–20 minutes. Additionally, there are proposals for air and helicopter ambulances as part of roadside amenities. These would include a helipad to quickly transport the patient directly to the hospital. We are developing 670 roadside amenities, each spanning 50–60 hectares, and they will have provisions for a helipad for emergency lifts and transport.

Q. You are also planning zero fatality corridors?
We are conducting road safety audits to identify the exact reasons for accidents and to correct any mistakes on our part. We have initiated a special course and are involving engineering colleges, particularly the civil engineering departments and IITs. We are providing them with a syllabus and requesting that, as students, they conduct road safety audits. So far, we have completed the audits of 20 roads, and we are making improvements based on those findings. Our goal is to conduct road safety audits for every national highway.

Q. India is party to the global mission to reduce road fatalities by half by 2030. This target has been getting deferred every few years. What is the current status?
I accept that I set the target. In every other subject, we've had success stories. But regarding this issue, I acknowledge we haven't achieved the target. We don't want to tell people it's not our fault; we accept responsibility. I take this issue very seriously, and if anyone points out problems, we are committed to addressing them. ■

"People here do not understand the impact of road rule violations and the huge loss of life it causes. Creating awareness is a big challenge"

"We need a fully intelligent traffic system everywhere to create awareness in people's minds. Public education is crucial too, especially in schools"